ministry official Braj Kumar (B. K.) Nehru only reinforced the link between India's economic vulnerability and the sustainability of its democratic nature.[94]

That May, an interagency group created at Eisenhower's behest recommended significant support for India through a soft-loan fund and the Export-Import Bank. A few days later, addressing the American people, the president stressed that a small amount of aid could "fatefully decide the difference between success and failure" in countries like India.[95] He asked Congress to fund a three-year $2 billion Development Loan Fund. C. Douglas Dillon, deputy under secretary of state for economic affairs, explained to Indian officials that the question of assistance to India was "one of amount and not of principle." To avoid the public back and forth that had followed the Indian request for wheat in 1950–1951—and the adverse impact it had had on the US-India relationship—they agreed to have quiet informal discussions before any formal request.[96]

However, as the situation deteriorated, forcing India to scale its development plan back somewhat, Nehru made India's needs public in September. Even as Indian officials were discussing economic assistance with Soviet officials, he stated that India would welcome $500 to $600 million in loans from the US. He also announced that finance minister T. T. Krishnamachari would travel to Britain, Canada, the US, and West Germany in September and October 1957 to seek grants, credit, and capital.[97]

Indians were not above citing Sino-Indian competition to make the case for assistance. Asked about "the race" by the *New York Times*, Nehru pointed to India's different approach, noting that while "we do not look upon it as a competition … inevitably comparisons are made." Visiting Washington, business leader Ghanshyam Das (G. D.) Birla emphasized that India was "the citadel in Asia against the spread of communism," and it was crucial that it win the "silent race" with China.[98]

Krishnamachari, too, was not shy about framing India's challenge in a way that would appeal to the US, emphasizing, "the battle here in India is a battle against communism too." In an interview before his departure, he warned that without aid, India would have to cut its economic plans drastically. He used the communist victory in Kerala to highlight the consequences of the shortage of resources for development. Krishnamachari